

WORDS OF PLAINNESS

Articles of Interfaith Discipleship — Sources & Methods

How the common-ground figures were reached

WORDS OF PLAINNESS · AARON POWNER PUBLISHING

This note explains where two figures used alongside the Articles come from, and how far they can be trusted. Both are reasoned estimates — drawn from the churches’ own confessions and from careful analysis — not the results of a survey. No one has polled the world’s Christians on this document. We set the method and its limits out plainly, so that anyone who wishes to weigh the claims can do so. The two figures rest on two different methods, measuring two different things, and are kept apart here on purpose.

I · “Roughly nineteen in twenty creedal Christians”

(Used of the nineteen shared declarations.)

What it means. The claim is made of each declaration, one at a time, and only of creedal Christians — the historic Trinitarian families who hold the Nicene confession. These are roughly nineteen in twenty of all who call themselves Christian: the Catholic, Orthodox, and historic Protestant communions, together with most independent and non-denominational churches. The word *creedal* is deliberate. Bodies that do not confess the Nicene faith are a separate question, treated under a wider reckoning, and the places where even creedal agreement runs out are named in a boundary list rather than hidden.

How it was reached. Each declaration begins in the recorded words of Jesus in the four gospels. It was framed at the point of consensus and checked, one tradition at a time, against that tradition’s own binding confessional documents — not against opinion, but against the texts each church uses to say what it believes. A declaration was rated by the share of creedal Christians whose own confessions would lead them to affirm it as written. Teachings that could not clear the bar were set aside into the boundary list rather than forced.

The result. Across the nineteen, the creedal figures cluster between 97 and 99 percent; the lowest that still pass sit near 94 to 95 percent; and one — the Lord’s Supper, where the manner of Christ’s presence divides the churches — is marked qualified near 92 percent. “Roughly nineteen in twenty” (95 percent) is therefore a conservative summary: the typical declaration scores higher. We rounded toward caution, not toward a flattering number.

Sources. The confessions consulted include the Catechism of the Catholic Church, the Westminster Confession, the Augsburg Confession and Formula of Concord, the Thirty-Nine Articles, the Baptist Faith and Message (2000), and the Articles of Faith of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. Population figures are drawn from the Center for the Study of Global Christianity’s *Status of Global Christianity, 2025*, the *World Christian Encyclopedia*, and the Pew Research Center.

What it is not. It is not a poll. It is an estimate of confessional agreement, built from the churches’ own documents and weighted by their sizes. The boundary list — the teachings that could not be shared even among creedal Christians — is part of the honesty of the method: it shows the same procedure can return a “no.”

2 · “On the order of nine in ten”

(Used of the moral vision of the Articles.)

What it means. This figure concerns the moral vision of the Articles — humility before mystery, mercy, grace, the refusal to gatekeep, fellowship across difference — and estimates the share of the world’s Christians likely to affirm it. It is a statement about ethics, not about doctrine.

How it was reached. Four independent artificial-intelligence systems, built by four different developers — Anthropic, Google, xAI, and Microsoft — were each given the same fixed instrument and asked the same question. Each weighed the document against the historic Christian families, scored its moral vision across five dimensions and its doctrine across seven, and weighted the result by the size of each family within global Christianity. Their estimates of moral affirmation converged closely, on the order of nine in ten.

Corroboration. The same finding was tested a second way. Four systems were asked to respond to the Articles in the voice of fifteen different readers. Across the Christian readers, the moral articles were affirmed while the doctrinal ones divided — the same shape the first method found. Two different approaches arrived at the same chord.

The figure that travels with it. The nine-in-ten figure never stands alone. The same study found that affirmation of the doctrine — and of holding it so plainly — is far more modest: below half, varying sharply from one tradition to the next, and estimated with considerably less agreement and less confidence than the moral figure. The distance between the two is the finding itself: Christians are divided from one another far less by ethics than by trust. To quote the high number without the modest one would misrepresent the study.

Sources. The four analyses are recorded in the bibliography of the AoID Receptivity Analysis; the demographic base is again the Center for the Study of Global Christianity (2025), the *World Christian Encyclopedia*, and Pew. The persona corroboration is recorded in the AoID Persona Testing collation.

What it is not. It is not a survey, and the four systems share common training, so their agreement is partly the agreement of close cousins rather than fully independent witnesses. The honest reading is to trust the shape of the finding — ethics widely shared, doctrine far less so — and to hold the exact figure loosely. We report it as “on the order of nine in ten,” never as a precise measurement.

3 · Two different measures, not one

The two figures land near each other, but they are not the same kind of evidence and should not be merged. The nineteen-in-twenty figure is confessional validation — each declaration checked against the churches’ own binding documents. The nine-in-ten figure is analytical estimation — the Articles’ moral vision weighed by independent systems against the Christian families. Different instrument, different object, different kind of confidence. Read together as if they were one study, the firmer measure would be weakened by the softer; read apart, each stands on its own footing.

4 · What these numbers are, and are not

Both figures are reasoned estimates, offered in good faith and with their limits in view. They are not opinion polls; no one has surveyed the world’s Christians on these statements. This note reports the method and the sources behind the figures, and the shape of what was found — not a ranking of one tradition against another. The fuller internal analysis, with its tradition-by-tradition detail, is kept as a working tool and is not published here, because its purpose is to prepare for honest conversation, not to grade anyone’s church.

We offer these figures the way we offer the Articles themselves: not as proof, but as the reason we keep setting the table.

“For my soul delighteth in plainness.”

— 2 Nephi 31:3